of the member states. India is committed to building up the rim association in line with its own expanding bilateral ties in the region. It sees merit in the expansion and further invigoration of its activities, from renewable energy and the blue economy to maritime safety and security, water science and greater institutional and think-tank networking.

Given the history and traditions of the Indian Ocean, it is but appropriate that any serious effort at promoting its coherence would address issues of its unity and identity. We must take full advantage of the ties of kinship and family that span the Indian Ocean and are an important part of its history. But more active initiatives are also needed and Project Mausam, whose very nomenclature, which is based on the distinctive wind system of the Indian Ocean, signifies interest in the characteristics of the region.

The project promotes archaeological and historical research on cultural, commercial and religious interactions. It has become a vehicle for knowledge exchanges, networking and publications. If this is an example of a contemporary initiative to revive the Ocean's identity, there are many other supporting endeavours that contribute to the same objective. By raising interest in traditional knowledge and practices such as ayurveda and yoga, by rekindling interest in the journey of faiths like Buddhism or Sufism, or by utilizing powerful symbols like Nalanda or Ramayana to promote human exchanges, we are step by step adding to the consciousness of an eco-system that was once secure in its vibrancy.

Clearly, much depends on how the possibilities of connectivity unfold in Asia. There are today various approaches and initiatives that offer choices to the nations of this region. Many would understandably like to make the best of all these opportunities. But the experiences of the last decade underline the importance of making mature and considered decisions in this regard. If connectivity is not to acquire sharp strategic meaning, then there must be credible assurances that projects are not used to exert influence. Similarly, unviable projects open up the possibility of being leveraged. It is also vital that sovereignty is respected, and disputed areas avoided in such endeavours. Connectivity must widen flows, not direct them.

The ethos of the Indian Ocean is a consultative one and in the long run, it is the people-centric initiatives and projects that are likely to be more